

Fertility Problems in Women

Although much more research is needed, herbal medicine does appear to increase fertility in women who are trying to conceive, especially if the problem is related to hormonal imbalances, age, or the amount of mucus produced by the cervix. Where there appears to be no physical problem preventing conception, for example a blocked fallopian tube, ovarian cysts, or internal scarring, herbal medicines are well worth trying. Diet, exercise, and lifestyle may also play a significant role in improving fertility.

Aiding Conception

Herb Chaste tree (*Vitex agnus-castus*, p. 151)

Remedy Take tablets or take 20–40 drops of tincture with water each morning for a maximum of 3 months at a time.

Herb Dong quai (*Angelica sinensis*, p. 63)

Remedy Take tablets or make a decoction using 12 g of root to 3 cups (750 ml) of water and drink each day for up to 3 months.

Caution Discontinue if you become pregnant.

Low Sex Drive

Herb Schisandra (*Schisandra chinensis*, p. 133)

Remedy Soak 5 g (a small handful) of berries in water overnight. Strain the berries and make a decoction with 1 cup (250 ml) of water. Brew for 15 minutes and take the dose each day.

Herb Shatavari (*Asparagus racemosus*, p. 174)

Remedy Take 1 tsp of tincture twice a day with water.

Fertility Problems in Men

Impotence in men is a common problem, and herbal medicine has been used throughout history to help restore healthy sexual function. A low sperm count, which is a common cause of infertility, is often related to lifestyle and general state of health.

Saw palmetto is a tonic herb that increases stamina. It benefits the male sexual organs and is reputed to increase potency.

Ashwagandha is an all-around tonic that is not as stimulating as ginseng, but is nonetheless helpful in restoring normal vitality after a long-term illness or stress.

General Vitality

Herb Ashwagandha (*Withania somnifera*, p. 152)

Remedy Take 2 g of the dried root a day, either by chewing it, or taking it in powder form mixed with honey and, if required, water. Take for up to 6 weeks.

Impotence & Premature Ejaculation

Herb Ginseng (*Panax ginseng*, p. 118)

Remedy Take 0.5–1 g up to 3 times a day for 6 weeks at a time, either by chewing the root, cooking it in a soup or stew, or taking it in tablet form.

Note Ginseng is the best-known remedy for this condition. However, schisandra (*Schisandra chinensis*, p. 133) berries also benefit male sexuality. Take as listed above in *Fertility Problems in Women* under *Low Sex Drive* for up to 6 weeks.

Caution Do not take caffeine while taking ginseng.

Herb Saw palmetto (*Serenoa repens*, p. 136)

Remedy Take ½ tsp of tincture with water up to 3 times a day for up to 6 weeks.

Note Saw palmetto is also an excellent remedy for symptoms associated with an enlarged prostate.

Menopausal Problems

Menopause is defined as the cessation of menstruation. It usually takes place between the ages of 45 and 55. After two years without having a period, you can be sure that the “change of life” has occurred.

Both estrogen and progesterone levels decline during menopause despite opinion to the contrary. Herbs such as chaste tree, which have a progestrogenic effect, are as important as those that support estrogen levels, since both hormones appear to help maintain bone density, reducing the risk of osteoporosis.

Maintaining vitality is important during menopause, since many problems result as much from being run-down and tired, as from hormonal changes. If you feel low and exhausted, some of these remedies may help to raise vitality and spirits. St. John's wort is an excellent medicine for depression.

Hot flashes and night sweats are principally caused by hormonal changes. However, nervous exhaustion increases the occurrence of these conditions.

General caution Seek professional advice if there is prolonged or irregular menstrual bleeding.

Decreased Estrogen & Progesterone Levels

Herb Chaste tree (*Vitex agnus-castus*, p. 151)

Remedy Take tablets, or 20–40 drops of tincture with water each morning.

Herb Shatavari (*Asparagus racemosus*, p. 174)

Remedy Take ½ tsp of tincture 2–3 times daily with water.

Herb Black cohosh (*Cimicifuga racemosa*, p. 79)

Remedy Take tablets, or take 25 drops of tincture with water 3 times a day.
Option Black cohosh combines well with sage. Mix equal parts of each tincture and take 30–40 drops (1.5–2 ml) with water 3 times a day.

Depression & Decreased Vitality

Herb St. John's wort (*Hypericum perforatum*, p. 106)

Remedy Take ½ tsp of tincture with water 3 times a day.

Herb Oats (*Avena sativa*, p. 175)

Remedy Eat 25–50 g of oats as a breakfast cereal, or with other food.

Option In addition, make an infusion with oat straw. Divide into 3 doses and drink throughout the day.

Hot Flashes & Night Sweats

Herb Sage (*Salvia officinalis*, p. 131)

Remedy Make an infusion and drink 1½ cups (450 ml), either during the day, or mainly at night, if this is when the problem chiefly occurs.

Herbs White willow (*Salix alba*, p. 129), black cohosh (*Cimicifuga racemosa*, p. 79)

Remedy Take one of the above herbs in tablet form, or take 1 tsp of tincture with water at night.

Herb White peony (*Paeonia lactiflora*, p. 117)

Remedy Make a decoction with 20 g root to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Sip throughout the day.